to the Soviet leadership for their support during the change of power in the SED by vowing to deepen their friendship: ‘The GDR was for all time a fixed, immovable part of the socialist community of states.’

Seated beneath him in the hall, Günter Schabowski was ‘surprised and relieved’ at Honecker’s performance. ‘We longed for a man at the top who could represent the Hallstein-banned GDR more convincingly … my scepticism gave way to a commitment to his politics.’3 If there was one criticism, Schabowski remembered, it was that the new First Secretary seemed decidedly uncharismatic in demeanour and speech. ‘He had an awkward manner, strained, high pitched voice, and a monotonous style of delivery.’

Leslie Colitt, the influential Financial Times correspondent in East Berlin, tartly remarked that there was no illusion of spontaneity, and any genuinely impromptu moments were isolated. ‘Honecker was a callow bureaucrat and terrible speaker, just like his predecessor. He is an apparatchik par excellence.’4 Even an admirer like interpreter Wolfgang Ghantus thought the obvious solution was to have some coaching, but Honecker shrugged off the suggestion. ‘He wasn’t a good speaker, he just read and spoke monotonously, without a full-stop or comma. It was terribly difficult to interpret. Margot was much better. She was intelligent and flexible.’5 Honecker particularly liked organised applause at the start of his speeches before he had done or said anything to merit it.

Another irritation, at least for photographers struggling to capture animated poses, was Honecker’s economy of gesture, though he did sometimes fidget and lick his lips. In Honecker’s defence, journalist Dieter Borkowski thought the new First Secretary lost his ‘inaccessible rigidity’ when ‘out-and-about meeting the public’. He addressed workers in friendly tones offering the the familiar ‘Du’, made contacts easily, spoke in simple vernacular, and even cracked jokes.6 He liked to address shop workers with explicit reference to his working-class origins and, in Borkowski’s opinion, his strength came from a ‘proletarian tone, chummy sociability in conversation’, and a less overbearing manner in dealing with the grassroots.7